PREFACE

Whereas it hath pleased the Author—who, having long toiled under the most delicate mixture of divine afflatus and bodily discomfort (to wit, cramped fingers, poor ventilation, and that particular nervous exhaustion which afflicts only those who invent whole worlds *ex nihilo*)—to undertake the composition of a history so unprecedented in scope, so labyrinthine in its structure, and so replete with the tears, exclamations, and mortal convictions of imaginary persons, it is now, with the full weight of authorial authority and the most sacred of narrative obligations, hereby declared—and not without a ceremonial flourish of the inkwell—that the present volume, hath been completed, affirmed, and confirmed, in all particulars, particulars sub-particular, and the sub-subsections thereof.

That is to say, every phrase hath been weighed as if on a jeweller's scale; every event hath been reviewed not once but thrice (once for accuracy, once for elegance, and a third time for moral edification); and the whole hath been sealed—mentally, spiritually, and symbolically—by its Originator and Sole Proprietor, whose lawful name is H. J. Darger.

Now, lest the reader (that most fickle of creatures, at once credulous and sceptical, childlike and censorious, ever hoping for dragons and doubting their wings) should err—either innocently or mischievously—in supposing the work to be open to augmentation, adaptation, contradiction, or public disputation, it must be stated in the most unequivocal terms available to the English tongue, that *no person living or dead*—not even those dwelling in the outer isles of editorial presumption or among the perfidious ranks of interpretive theorists—shall be permitted to issue proclamations to the effect that this narrative is "true," or "false," or "nearly true," or "an allegory for industrial capitalism," or indeed to make any such interpolations, amendments, asides, appendices, glossaries, prefaces, or "fan tributes," as the vulgar now say, without the explicit and notarized consent of said H. J. Darger, who is by divine and legal right the First and Final Voice of this creation.

Nor shall it ever be duplicated, refracted, remixed, or resold under any guise of truth, falsehood, or metaphorical significance. Nay, it shall remain inviolate, a singular monument to the sacred right of the individual imagination to conjure nations from dust, and to endow suffering with the dignity of invented names.

Thus, with hand unshaken and pen unyielding, the Author doth set his name—not with pride (though some pride is inevitable), nor with anger (though some indignation is just), but with the unshakeable conviction that what hath been written is fixed, and what is fixed, like the stars, may not be moved save by God or a sufficiently persuasive footnote.

Signed, in the Year of Authorship (the precise calendar reckoning being of secondary importance),
H. J. Darger, *Originator and Sole Proprietor of the Realms Unreal,*
Author of the History Entire, Protector of the Vivian Lineage,
& Declarer of Narrative Boundaries in This and All Subsequent Universes.

INTRODUCTION

I

It hath been said, by men more learned than I, that there are few endeavours more perilous—nor indeed more presumptuous—than to undertake the full and faithful narration of a war, especially one of so fabulous a complexion as the present, which, although it be cloaked in the garb of allegory or phantasm, yet exhibits all the real terrors, stratagems, betrayals, sieges, tumults, and heroical excesses of any campaign undertaken by Caesar, Cromwell, or the more recent (and less philosophically inclined) Bonaparte.

Now, Dear Reader (for I do flatter myself that I am addressing one possessed of patience, discernment, and, if I may hazard the compliment, a peculiar fondness for long sentences), you are entreated to make some allowance—for both your present narrator, and for the enormity of the undertaking before him. The history I have composed—yea, laboured over, line by line, stroke by stroke, as the monk his illuminated gospel or the clockmaker his escapement—compriseth the events of a war which, in duration, exceeded even that ancient contest between Sparta and Athens so chronicled by Thucydides, and which in horror, I dare say, outstripped the Thirty Years' War, the Napoleonic convulsions, and even those domestic contentions (so impolitely styled "civil") which sundered the United States of America.

For to speak precisely, the *Glandeco-Angelinian War* (so named after the principal powers therein engaged, although it would be more accurate to include the beleaguered Calverinians and the proud yet oft-humbled Abbieannians as equal participants) endured no less than *forty-three years and seven months*—an interval long enough for a generation to be born, labour, decay, and perish beneath its shadow. During this interval, which must be understood not merely as a chronological span but as a crucible of human suffering and divine retribution, the forces of Christianity contended with an adversary of such protean cruelty and mystifying intent, that no less a mind than my own (having applied to it all the methods of induction, analogy, and patient collation) was able to resolve its mystery with clarity.

I speak, of course, of the *Aronburg Mystery*—that dark and twisting skein of crime and prophecy, which, like some malignant thread, ran through the whole of the conflict, knotting itself about. The murder (or, as some impiously whisper, the *sacrifice*) of the Child of Aronburg shook the administrations of the Three Christian States. That such an event could threaten to undo the martial enterprises of entire nations may seem incredible—but history, alas, is replete with instances wherein a single death hath proved more determinative than a thousand swords.

Indeed, had not the tide of fortune been reversed—providentially, I might add, though I leave final judgment to the Divine—at the infamous Battle of Aronburg's Run (a name now synonymous with terror, mud, and slaughter), it is altogether likely that the Christian Alliance would have collapsed, their banners trampled, their manufactories razed, and their faith reduced to whispers in the wilderness. But as it happened (and with what effort, sacrifice, and stratagem!), the armies of Abbieannia struck a blow so decisive against the Glandelinians that even their most vainglorious ministers were compelled to sue for quarter.

Yet, gentle Reader, this triumph was dearly bought. *Calverinia*—once a flourishing land of artisans and humble worshippers—was so thoroughly laid waste as to become a spectre of itself, her children sold into misery, her chapels desecrated, her ports smouldering. *Angelinia*, too, that proud and haughty nation, was left with scarcely enough blood to fill her conscription rolls, let alone her tea-cups. What had begun as a righteous campaign, waged in the name of divine justice and civil order, ended with barely a stone left standing atop its fellow.

But of these particulars you shall hear more anon—for I have not spent eleven years in the patient accumulation of documents, diaries, oral confessions, battlefield sketches, hagiographies, and obscure parliamentary minutes, merely to dispense them in a vulgar haste. Each detail (believe me, good Reader) hath been sifted, weighed, and arranged with the utmost care, that it might furnish not only a narrative of events, but a kind of moral reckoning—a mirror in which the follies of princes, the crimes of ambition, and the sufferings of the small may be studied by all posterity.

Thus begins the present History—if not the greatest ever written, then at least the most singular—being the record of a war both fabulous and

real, sacred and absurd, written by one who, though perhaps unequal to the subject, hath dared to face it.

Finis Præfationis. Let us now descend from the clouds and enter the field.

II

Abandon now, if you will, the comforting proportions of our modest globe, the pious rivalries of its sects, and the polite hostilities of its empires; and consider, instead, a planet of such stupefying magnitude and baroque complexity, that the whole of Europe—yea, even the entire terrestrial sphere with its London, its Leipzig, its Calcutta, and its Canton—might be suspended in a single basin of its smallest sea, like an apple in the washbowl of an indifferent footman.

This, then, is the stage: a planet unnamed, but one whose moon, most curiously, is *our* Earth. That is to say, we, in this present life, revolve as a lesser light about a greater fire, peering up at a firmament that (if one is inclined to take one's metaphysics with a tincture of romance) may regard us with no more seriousness than we regard the scuttling of a cheese-mite.

Upon this prodigious sphere lie scattered—in forms uncannily reminiscent of our own—the nations of *Glandelinia* and its rivals: *Angelinia*, *Abyssinkile*, *Protestentia*, and *Abbieannia*. It must here be observed that although all these states are avowedly *Catholic*—some with an ardour bordering on mania—not one Protestant nation exists among them, a fact that the Author cannot help but find most unsettling.

Permit me a brief digression, not wholly alien to the matter at hand. If the *Angelininian Sea* be vast enough to swallow our Earth a dozen times over, the *Mo-Whirthian Sea* is its ungovernable sibling: a body of water so prone to convulsions of heat and fury that it heaves and buckles with waves of molten wrath, dragging polar winds from the Calverinian front like an offended duchess drawing her shawl against a low-born impertinence.

Typhoons descend there with such regularity and ferocity that no soul dares a cross it. Amidst the waves which, I am told, rise to heights unknown since the Deluge, rise the enigmatic *Blengiglomenean Islands*; whose rocky coasts bear the wreckage of many a tradeship. Legends abound regarding its location and equally inscrutable inhabitants; legends whose veracity this

author doubts, given the nations' zeal, and the physical impossibility of the claims, which I will thoroughly dispel at a later point in this volume.

But enough of oceans—let us now turn to *persons*.

Of all the bewildering multitude of inhabitants—some trillions of men, with as many women and not a few children—none are more consequential to our tale than the esteemed Governor *Hanson Vivian*, his brother and fellow magistrate *Robert Angelic Vivian*, and their respective ladies—women of unearthly charm, it is said, whose social grace belied a courage worthy of the Cumaean Sibyl.

The Vivian Girls, however—those luminous innocents, so radiant as to elude all painterly capture—must occupy the centre of our regard. Their beauty, to speak of it directly, would defeat even the most florid vocabulary of M. d'Alembert or Mr. Pope; and their sufferings (for such sweetness seldom escapes the designs of tyrants) were of a sort that may give pause to even the most stony-hearted reader. You will hear, in due course, of their imprisonment at Calverinia—and later at Andrean, where the air was thick with the sighs of the unjustly confined, and even the vermin seemed to weep.

But do not weep yet, my Dear Reader. For before the Great War there were moments, precious and improbable, of levity, intrigue, and even the exquisite awkwardness of courtly flirtation. And of these, too, you shall hear. For though our tale begins in a world more vast than any atlas can contain, its heart beats, as all true stories do, in the small gestures: a glance withheld, a bow too deep, a question asked with too much feeling and answered with too little.

But I digress—as is my wont and, I trust, my Reader's indulgence.

CHAPTER ONE

I

A shadow passed over the estate of Governor Hanson Vivian, as, far above, in the scorched heavens of Calverinia, a procession of scarlet clouds were driven onward by the breath of a cold front. The property, known officially as *Vervain-House* but more commonly as '*Hanson's Folly*,'[1] lay some seventeen metres inland from the port of Pandora, reached by a serpentine carriage-path paved in crushed porcelain tiles. Of the structure, scarcely more than a sixth was occupied by the Governor himself or his immediate household; the remainder was given over to attachés, sub-clerks, natural philosophers, and other such persons whose weight, social or speculative, inclines them toward the vicinity of power.

Shortly before noon, on the fifth of April, 1801, Governor Robert Vivian—recently arrived after a three-day passage aboard the packet-ship *Isabel Marchioness*—rang the ceremonial bell at the estate's main entrance. The household, in its daily operations, was entrusted largely to a Mr. Frickle, a domestic of precise habits and faded maroon livery. He opened the door with a reluctance so carefully maintained that it appeared less a reaction than a duty.

"Sir," he began, eyeing not the man but the bundle which he bore slung under one arm in the manner of a tradesman, "your name?"

The Governor—for so he must, despite appearances, still be styled—responded with a quiet civility that bespoke an education not recent. "Governor Robert Angelic Vivian—though I daresay I may look worse for wear."

There are, it must be admitted, few spectacles more perplexing to a well-regulated household than that of a Governor who arrives without

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[1] Vervain-House did not obtain this particular sobriquet until after Bloody Easter. Though considered distasteful by those who relish in displays of public virtue—the publicans, the journalists, the clerics, *et cetera*—the name was popular nevertheless, given the overall cost of construction of the building proper (£17,591,767) and subsequent losses (personal and financial) the Governor incurred following its destruction.

retinue, bears his own luggage, and requests admittance as though he were a solicitor. Mr. Frickle, whose experience extended to many varieties of impropriety, found this particular instance difficult to classify. Eventually Robert was admitted to a vestibule of middling dimension, where he was transferred to the custody of a second servant. This latter functionary, Mr. Prang, wore a black dress coat of funereal cut, and silver-rimmed spectacles, which he wore at the end of his nose, so it seemed he was always peering down at his fellows.

"If your 'Excellency'"—(for so he said it, though not without a flare of the nostrils)—"would be pleased to deposit your bundle here and await further instructions, I shall communicate your presence to the Secretary, who will, in the ordinary course, inform the Governor—His Excellency, I mean—when his affairs permit interruption."

To which Governor Robert, taking a seat uninvited, replied, "If it's all the same, I should much rather wait with you. I've no stomach for drawing-rooms, and you seem"—he paused—"a man of some conversation."

"But—Sir—Excellency," stammered Prang, "you are a guest—a visitor of honour, if I may say so—your station requires—"

"Only a pipe," quoth Robert, producing one from his coat. "I've not had a puff in three hours and fear my spirits may become unsettled by continued abstinence."

"A pipe!" exclaimed the man, blinking. "In the vestibule? Heaven forbid. What next—billiards in the linen-closet?"

"My dear man," said the Governor, smiling, "I would no more smoke in your vestibule than I would write poetry in a ledger. But if there be any corner of this great house not governed by the law, then I shall smoke in it!"

Mr. Prang, rather than replying, began to mutter beneath his breath. "How the devil am I to announce such a man?" he said, apparently to his own breeches. "In the first place, he has no valet; in the second, he carries his own luggage; and in the third—Heaven help us!—he wishes to *smoke*."

"Do you intend to take up your abode with us?" he asked.

"No, I do not think I shall stay," said the Governor. "I come to deliver some news of substantial import, nothing more."

It was at this juncture that Governor Hanson entered the vestibule. Whereupon Robert, without rising, but straightening some six vertebrae, turned to acknowledge his brother's arrival.

"Your Honour," said Mr. Prang, now bowing, "this gentleman declares himself to be the Governor Robert Vivian, and, as such, begs audience. He has but just now arrived—though he brings with him no additional luggage, retinue, nor even a proper seal."

Hanson, after listening with a composed mien, dismissed Mr. Prang with the faintest motion of the left eyebrow, and extended a hand toward his brother.

"You have travelled far, and lightly, Robert."

"I have," he said, gravely.

Mr. Prang, meanwhile, had stepped back two paces—ostensibly out of respect, though more likely to better observe.

"Well," said Hanson, after a silence measured precisely by the creak of the coffer clock, "Mr. Prang, you are dismissed." He turned to his brother. "I have yet to finish reconciling the figures from the coastal levies—but do come in."

II

As Hanson led Robert through the foyer, up the grand staircase, and down a vast hall lined with busts of Diderot, Rousseau, Voltaire, and other such luminaries; he could hear, distantly, the sound of a party ongoing. At last they arrived at black pinewood door marked "Study"; the door was opened, and Robert could now see, beyond a veil of smoke, assembled within, the principal dignitaries of Calverinia, namely, the Magistrate of the Mint, the Surveyor of Canals, a Deputy of the Board of Ecclesiastical Exceptions, together with several other gentlemen whose functions I have not since been able wholly to ascertain, though I have no doubt they were useful in their way.

Hanson seated himself upon a floral-patterned chaise beside the Archbishop of Cantburg. The Archbishop rose at once and offered Robert his place, Robert declined it and remained standing before his brother.

"My brother," he said, "I come with intelligence of an urgent nature."

It may be thought that such an announcement would have commanded immediate attention; yet Hanson, after hearing him perfectly well made no reply, but instead signalled to Mr. Prang. A bottle of brandy was brought, together with two glasses, and while this was being arranged Hanson said, in a tone without haste, "Have a drink, Robert. Celebrate."

"Hanson, did you not hear me?" Robert returned.

"Of course I did. Drink, I insist."

The glass was placed in Robert's hand, and he set it down upon a small table at his side.

"Manners, Robert," said Hanson quietly. "Do use a coaster."

At this Mr. Prang, who had not withdrawn beyond earshot, slipped a small disc of cork beneath the glass with a dexterity that might almost have been called affectionate, and vanished again.

"You should know," he began, "that our nation has recently established a trade agreement with Glandelinia."

Robert said nothing. Hanson continued, "Yes, I know you disapprove—but they are building the future."

"You mean their slaves are," Robert replied.

There was no change in Hanson's expression; indeed, if anything, he seemed to become more composed. "I admit," he said, "that their methods leave much to be desired; but consider the advances they have made in manufacturing. They produce goods at an unprecedented scale. Think of the benefit that could be done for our people if we were to do likewise."

Robert raised the glass and drank. Hanson smiled. *Patience*, he thought, *you have Reason on your side.*

"Will you have your children be slaves?" Robert asked.

"Heavens, no," said Hanson, with a short laugh. "We are an enlightened people. I intend to provide *employment*. This will grow our economy. Consider—we may yet cultivate a middle class."

"And those beneath it?" Robert said.

"Ah, my brother the altruist—"

"You think I jest?"

"I think," Hanson replied, pausing to sip, "that you ought to consider the long-term. It is a new century."

"Hanson," said Robert, setting down his glass, "there is a storm approaching."

Hanson reclined, one leg crossed over the other, and remarked, with fraternal indifference, "I believe, Brother, you have mistaken the office of Governor for that of Cassandra."

And, almost as though in conspiracy to furnish a rejoinder to Hanson's verbal shaft, the room responded with an outbreak of laughter so

sudden, so volcanic, and so wholly unfitted to the dignity of the assembly, that one might have supposed the floorboards themselves were tickled from beneath. Monocles were dislodged, snuffboxes overturned, and several gentlemen—unaccustomed, it would seem, to the physical exertions of mirth—were observed to clutch at their sides as though struck by shot. In one particularly unfortunate instance, the Honourable Mr. Leech[2]—whose constitution had long exhibited a certain delicacy—suffered a brief but total evacuation of his bowels.

"My dear brother," began Hanson, his voice neither raised in alarm nor tremulous with emotion, "I confess myself troubled—though not, as you suppose, by the weather—but by your sudden abandonment of Reason."

In that moment, the door opened with unexpected force, and his youngest daughter, Miss Anna Bell, came into the room, and she threw herself into her father's arms with such effect that the brandy was within an inch of being lost, had not Mr. Prang interposed in time to save both liquor and carpet. Lady Lavernia followed at a slower pace, as indeed became her. She took the seat which Robert had declined, and said, "I apologize, Hanson. I told her you were engaged, but she would not be persuaded."

"Father! Father!" cried the child, who had by now fastened upon his lapels with both hands.

"What is it, my little Duchess?"

"Clary has stolen Sarah Beth, Father!"

"Who is Sarah Beth?" he asked, and looked at his wife, who, with that silent economy of expression peculiar to long marriages, mouthed the words, "Her doll."

A change, slight but sufficient, came over his face. "Oh dear," he said, "what a dreadful thing to do."

"Make her give it back, Father. Pretty please!"

It may be thought that a matter so urgent to the child might have demanded immediate redress; but Hanson, who was not without resource in such situations, said instead, "I will tell you what—you go with your mother to the kitchen, and they shall make your favourite tart. Would you like that?"

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[2] The Author extends his deepest condolences to the Leech family, who have experienced, recently, the loss of their patriarch to dysentery.

The grievance was forgotten, or at least suspended, and the child, having signified her assent with a vigour that admitted no doubt, was dismissed.

"What are you waiting for?" he added lightly. "Off with you—tarts do not wait."

She ran out at once, and Lady Lavernia followed, calling after her not to run, which she did not obey.

Hanson called for more brandy.

Mr. Prang returned, and while he was pouring, Robert, who had borne the interruption with less impatience than might have been expected, said, "Will you not consider what I am saying?"

Hanson drank, not hastily, but entirely, and then, rising a little and turning towards the windows, said, "You may see for yourself. Indeed, if you wish for confirmation, you may consult the Chairman of the Board of Meteorology. He is here somewhere. Templeton! Templeton, if you please!" He looked about the room as he spoke, though whether he expected an answer I cannot say.

"I care nothing for your meteorologist," said Robert. "I have seen it. I was there. I went as far as the Catherine Isles, and we barely escaped with our lives. The *Isabel Marchioness* took me aboard when I was adrift in the Mo-Whirthian Sea. We outran the storm by a single day. Hanson, I beg you—leave this while there is time."

"I have had enough of this," Hanson returned. "You are a statesman, Robert—not a man of science, nor a prophet. You understand the laws of nature no more than—well—than Newton would understand verse. The Easter festivities will proceed as planned. You are welcome to attend, if you will put aside these fancies."

Up to this point Robert had spoken as one arguing, and Hanson as one dismissing argument; but what followed was of another kind altogether. Robert stood still for a moment, and when he spoke again it was not in the tone he had hitherto used, but in one lower, and yet more carrying, so that the room, which had till then continued in its ordinary murmur, began insensibly to grow quiet.

"*I wander through each chartered street*," he said, and though I, nor anyone else could understand why he should choose to express himself in this

manner, it appears to me now less persuasion than proclamation. "*Near where the charted winds do blow—*"

There was a pause, or something like one, though the words continued. By this time the company had fallen silent.

"And every gaze bore dread, and each soul ill,
As if the clouds themselves had come to close.
In every cry I heard the typhoon's tread,
In every shuttered home, the storm's grim breath,
And the bells rang omens for the dead."

Here the company began to draw back. At this point Anna Bell had returned unnoticed, and was now half concealed behind a curtain, watching with rapt attention.

III

The party adjourned. It was the speech—or, I suppose, the "prophecy"—of Robert Vivian which had effected this dissolution, and which shall, I dare wager, endure in the public memory as one of those utterances that, whether or not they altered the course of history, most assuredly rearranged the metaphysical furniture of all who heard it. So direct were his invocations of ruin that a few guests were seen staring nervously toward the window, as though to assure themselves the sea had not risen up to the second storey.

Hanson retired to his bedchamber at the customary hour of ten o'clock. It was Easter Eve, after all, and Hanson had determined that no external cause could possibly displace his private repose.

Yet Nature, who so often delights in exposing the fragility of human foresight—whether in the form of plague, revolution, or deluge—did not permit him rest. For the air became dense and sulphurous. The temperature had risen to so improbable a degree that brass door-knobs were said to have blistered the servants' fingers.

Nevertheless, as it so often happens, the dawn did break, and not with the dramatic devastation one might have expected from Robert's prophecy, but rather with gray skies, a high southwesterly wind (the kind that tangles

hair and disrupts the orderly procession of hats), and, by nine o'clock, a wholly inappropriate abundance of sunshine.

Having concluded his morning walk through the South Garden, Robert, dressed again in his seaworn naval uniform, set out alone upon a private errand of reflection, observation, and prayer.

By the third hour, the air had begun to thicken. Not with mist, nor with any particulate observable to the common eye, but with something more insidious: a suffusion of hue, a chromatic nausea, whereby the ordinary blue of the upper heavens had curdled into an unwholesome yellow.

With halting steps he paced the streets. Such dreary streets! Little more than hovels on either hand, and here and there a beggar seeking alms. At this hour of the morning, on Easter Sunday, that quarter of the town proved all but deserted. But presently Robert came to a low, wide building, the door of which stood invitingly open. Above his head he heard a forlorn creaking in the air; and looking up, saw a swinging sign over the door with a white painted cross, and these words underneath—"The Church of Saint Dismas."

Upon entering the chapel he found a small and scattered congregation of sailors and their wives, and, alas, in no small number, their widows. Within, the air was dry, and smelled faintly of old stone and extinguished candles. The pews were worm-softened, sun-bleached, and each subtly warped by the moisture that visited nightly from the coast—and the light that fell through the coloured panes at the east end was now wholly subjugated by the yellowed firmament outside, rendering the saints in glass wan and spectral.

Robert seated himself in the rear-most pew, where the light from the apse no longer reached. The yellow glow outside had deepened into something more brassy. And through the upper windows he saw not clouds, but a kind of undulation in the sky—too slow for smoke, too sinuous for wind—like the shudder of invisible creatures vast and nameless, stirring in Heaven's womb.

At that instant, the eyes of the entire congregation turned as one toward the figure who entered.

The man who now appeared before them was of a certain venerable robustness. It was Father Malthus. Robert could tell by his appearance that he had arrived on foot: his forehead ran rivulets from his brow down to the base of his chin; his pilot-cloth overcoat, saturated to the point of liquefaction, threatened to peel away from his person under the weight of his perspiration.

These several garments he hung in an orderly manner upon the pegs of a humble wooden rack, and beneath all this armor there emerged, at last, a figure in black worsted: a priest's habit, unadorned, unfrivolous, and yet more dignified for its severity. In this unpretending garb, Malthus advanced toward the pulpit.

The pulpit was of an exceedingly peculiar design. Lofty it was, to be sure, in that ancient manner which demands the preacher tower over the flock as Moses over the Israelites. Yet the architecture had been subject to certain spatial constraints, and it was evident to any man with an eye for blueprints that a standard staircase would have robbed the nave of vital floor space. The solution, as it turned out, had issued from Malthus himself: namely, to install a vertical ladder, not unlike those employed in scaling a ship's side from the waterline—a form which, while perilous, imparted to the ascent a certain martial sanctity, as if the preacher must first *board* the vessel of the Word before he could command it.

The ladder was furnished with scarlet ropes, whose knobs glistened with damp. These Malthus grasped with both hands, cast one upward glance, and then, with the precision of an old topman, began his ascent. Hand over hand, foot over foot, he mounted, not in haste, but with that deliberate grace by which duty sanctifies effort.

But what followed startled even Robert. Upon gaining the topmost rung and stepping squarely into the pulpit's enclosure—a space enclosed on three sides, like a turret—the Reverend stooped, and, with studied care, drew the ladder up after him, rung by rung, until the last segment was housed within, and he stood alone, inaccessible, in a kind of airborne bastion. The effect was less that of preacher than of commander withdrawing the gangplank before a siege.—*He had sealed himself in.*

Indeed, the pulpit itself bore testimony to the chaplain's former life upon the ocean. Its panelled face resembled the bow of a ship. A carved projection, shaped in the likeness of a fiddle-headed beak, jutted forward to cradle the Holy Bible, which lay open, fluttering faintly as if stirred by a wind not of this world. This was no mere lectern; it was a prow.

Father Malthus cleared his throat. His voice, when it issued forth, was of that curious timbre—sonorous, slow, and deliberate, as though the soul were being decanted through the lungs.

"My dear brethren," he began, "attend now—not merely with the ears of flesh, but with that inward ear which God Himself hath hollowed in the conscience of man. For to-day, I propose not a story, but a warning; not a psalm of comfort, but a trumpet of dread."

Here he paused, the air outside grew perceptibly more silent—so silent, indeed, that the creak of the pews was heard as if magnified through an ear-trumpet. The congregation, that earlier had fidgeted with fans and beads and the nervous paraphernalia of devotional boredom, now sat motionless.

"It is recorded," Malthus continued, "in that ancient register of divine and geological precedent, the Book of Genesis, that there was once a world so thoroughly given over to corruption, that the Lord resolved to cleanse the whole terrestrial sphere by means of aqueous annihilation. But this was no mere whim—it was the logical consequence of unbridled Chaos.

"Noah," he continued, "being a man of upright bearing and commendable industriousness was instructed to build an Ark."

At this moment, some unseen meteorological drama began to unfold without: a soundless convulsion of the heavens, in which the upper strata of clouds—until now a dull violet—began to fold and unfold in tremendous globular volumes, like the lungs of a colossus breathing its final, most terrible breath. Their hue deepened to a bruised black, tinged with opalescent smears of green, sulphur-yellow, and an alarming shade not unlike dried blood diluted in ink.

"But let us return to the Deluge," he intoned, as the shadows deepened in the nave. "The rain descended in sheets, torrents, so that the very firmament were ripped open by Divine decree, and the waters of the deep were summoned forth—"

As the preacher's oration reached its climax—a thunderous booming was heard from the distant horizon: something primal. The congregation collectively gasped. An infant whimpered. A fisherman dropped his prayer-book. Father Malthus, unstartled, lifted both hands—palms outward, fingers like wheel-spokes—and exclaimed with calm force: "Let none depart! This House is no less of an Ark, and we are not yet drowned!"

The congregation, who moments earlier might have mistaken his tale for a vivid excursus into Mosaic cosmogony, now stared with unfeigned alarm, for the air pressure had dropped perceptibly and a faint acrid tang now attended each breath.

"Pray," said Malthus, lowering his voice, "that ye may be found, not as the men of the Old World, who laughed at He who sealed their doom, but as those few who entered the Ark with trembling obedience and emerged upon a world made new."

Here he knelt—his gaunt frame collapsing upon the pulpit's bow, and, crossing his large, workworn hands upon his chest, lifted his eyes, now shut, toward that black and curdled sky.

Outside, a second peal of thunder, lower and more sustained, began to roll over the town like the Chariot of God. The timbers of the chapel groaned.

Within, the silence was absolute, and yet pregnant with penance.

Father Malthus began to pray.

And the air acquired a noxious quality, and the thunder, once confined to mere mutterings, began to amplify. Outside the window, Robert could see from the south a roaming band of clouds most furious. The sound accompanying this multidirectional convulsion was neither wind nor thunder alone, but some third and unnamed element—an acoustic chimæra, if you will—which tore at the very foundations of the chapel. The pews began to tremble; the candelabra swung violently in their chains; motes of ancient dust descended from the roofbeams. And it was in this moment that Robert rose from his seat and fled for the door with all the speed his legs and conscience could muster—the rest of the congregation, and Father Malthus, remained locked in devotional posture, their lips moving in unison.

The floor heaved and tilted, and Robert—having reached within mere feet of the exit—was dashed to the ground.

And the wind sundered the chapel clean in twain, leaving naught but the barest floorboards to testify to its former sanctity. Upon these, Robert lay prostrate, his hair and garments flattened by the gale. His eyes beheld Father Malthus, arms outstretched in cruciform, together with his rapt congregation, now aloft. In their ascension there was neither scream nor supplication, but a kind of resigned grace, such as one sees in the portraits of martyrs. In a matter of seconds, they were gone. The chapel, emptied of sound save the wind's receding howl, stood stripped of its function, its furniture, and its faithful.

The storm had arrived.

IV

Robert ran with what breath and balance remained to him through the collapsing streets of Pandora, crying out between fitful mutterings of "Ave Maria" and curses unprintable. His object was singular and urgent: to reach Vervain-House and there, if heaven permitted, to find his brother Hanson alive and unperforated.

Women shrieked from upper balconies, men carried children beneath arms like parcels, dogs howled at the sky, and carts overturned in the narrow streets as their drivers abandoned them for whatever refuge could be had. From every corner of the city arose the manifold cries of its inhabitants—each voice bearing some peculiar tone of despair or supplication—while mingled among them was the ever-intensifying tumult of the storm itself, a sound so strange that one might well have supposed (as Robert indeed *did* suppose) that the very sky was unseaming. The heavens, it should be noted, had turned a colour not properly belonging to any known spectrum—being neither wholly black nor merely grey, but suffused with a kind of sickly ochre, against which the green of the trees, the ivy, and the surrounding meadows shone with an unearthly phosphorescence.

Hot gusts of wind—intermittent yet furious—swept through the avenues like invisible bellows, lifting dust and leaves into the air, while the first raindrops began to strike the wooden façades and cobbled streets with a report as loud as gunfire, and a splatter as large as a grown man's pate. These drops did not fall so much as hurl themselves earthward in righteous fury.

And still Robert ran, though now unable to see more than a few yards ahead, so rapidly had the darkness descended, which no lamp could pierce save for those terrible flashes of lightning from above. One such bolt burst from the clouds like a whip and struck so near to Robert's path that it burnt his eyes like powdered cayenne. The thunder that followed was not a single clap, but a barrage—indeed, a salvo—more akin to a battery of field-artillery than any mere aerial discharge: and with it came the ruin of Vervain-House.

The great manor collapsed in a manner so total, so irreversibly instantaneous, that one might be excused for supposing it had never stood at all. Shards of timber, roof-slate, window-frame, and curtain-rod fell from above as though hurled by God himself; and amidst this downward torrent Robert fled to the mud-riven garden.

The palm trees, once proud and stately, now whipped to and fro, their leaves slashing the air, their trunks bowing to unnatural angles. The garden statuary had fractured into a thousand shrieking fragments, which now flew about the yard like cannonballs. One headless Cupid shot past Robert's ear, pushing a gust of wind against his cheek.

He reached the Vivian family crypt, and there, exerting a strength born not of musculature but of desperation, prised open the iron door and slipped inside. Leaving the door just slightly ajar, he beheld, through the narrow aperture, a most astonishing vision: a canopy of crimson clouds, intricately veined with black and violet. They brought with them a strange radiance which illuminated the southern and western horizons.

The noise now redoubled—yea, tripled—in ferocity: above the usual thunder there rose a more piercing tone, metallic and high, and then a singular explosion that shook down the buildings that had not already collapsed.

And then, without warning, a flash of lightning so blinding, so total, that it rendered all other light void, split the air into prismatic rivulets and set the very ground trembling beneath Robert's feet. Another followed, then another, each with forked extremities that seemed to seek out the tallest structures, or the proudest, or the most beloved—and found them. The storm, now at its peak, howled with the voice of a million furies, and the rain, which had before been fierce, now descended in sheets so dense, so voluminous, that vision was restricted to less than six feet in any direction.

How long this aerial siege continued, Robert could not precisely say. The sounds of ruin persisted with such totality that silence itself, when it came at last, seemed no less an auditory shock. The rain continued to fall, albeit now with gentle indifference. The great bowl of wrath had finally been emptied, and what remained was merely the slow percolation of water through the thousand apertures now newly-made in the ruined world.

Upon stepping forth from the crypt, Robert saw the garden had been transformed into a marsh, wherein fragments of sculpture protruded like relics. The palms had been variously snapped, flung, and decapitated, the ground being littered with fronds. Here, Robert saw a rosewood wardrobe, half-buried in clay; there, the porcelain fragments of Lady Lavernia's cherished washbasin; and floating overhead, the fluttering remnants of correspondence, account-books, and legal forms.

Robert called his brother's name—*"Hanson!"*

Above, gulls circled. Making his way through the quagmire, Robert approached the wreckage of Vervain-House, now a cathedral of split beams and cracked marble. No chamber remained intact.

Calling again—*"Hanson!"*—Robert stepped lightly to avoid a particularly offensive stench issuing from the ruptured conduit of a septic drain, though in so doing he dislodged a precarious lattice of laths and ceiling joists which fell in a flurry of noise and dust. And then—a voice! Familiar, irksomely so.

"Hello? Who is that?" came the call, in a tone that suggested the speaker had just been awoken from a nap.

There could be no mistake. The voice belonged to Hanson. Dashing with renewed urgency, Robert pressed forward, calling again and again his brother's name, as if the syllables themselves could exhume the fellow. And lo! There he was—Hanson, pinned beneath the family's grand piano, purchased for the musical education of Anna Bell, whom he had intended to fashion into the next Mozart.

"R-Robert...?" came Hanson's voice again. He could not move. His face gave all the pleading that his lips would not. "I can't breathe, Robert," he said at last.

"No?" Robert replied, with a degree of studied obliviousness.

"No..." said Hanson, more plaintively.

Robert nodded. "That is a shame."

From somewhere in the vicinity of a collapsed pantry, came another voice: "*Help! Please!*"

Robert cocked his ear. "Ah," he said, "that would be Mr. Prang. If you will excuse me, brother Hanson," Robert said, brushing ash from his lapel, "I believe your manservant requires my assistance."

Hanson said nothing, but his eyes, bulging slightly from under the piano lid, delivered a look of abject flabbergast. Unable to contain the internal combustion of his wounded authority, he exhaled a declaration: "*I am a Man of the State!*"

But alas, Robert had already vanished from view. And so Hanson, alone, turned his gaze upward—not toward Heaven in the devotional sense, but rather toward the ragged sky now visible through what had formerly been the ceiling of the study. *Assist the manservant?* he thought, his mind wheeling.

What new polity have I awakened to, where the masters grovel and the help scream unsupervised?

Turning his head, with no small effort and considerable crepitation of vertebrae, Hanson beheld a sight more calamitous to his temperament than even the crushing weight of mahogany: pages—*his* pages—strewn across the mud like carnival litter—*charters, protocols, yield-tables, maritime quotas*. One might as well have torched the mint or pissed on the Constitution.

His heart, which had hitherto been preoccupied with the more immediate business of remaining functional under compression, now sank with sudden alacrity. *How could I have been so blind?* he thought. There must, he reasoned, have been a defect in the barometer, or perhaps in the triple-scale aerometric dial. Perhaps he ought to have invested in instruments of *Glandelinian* manufacture. Say what one will of the Glandelinians—they did know how to engineer a pressure gauge. But before he could complete this train of thought there came a noise above: the unmistakable crunch of broken plaster underboot, accompanied by the popping tinkle of shattered glass. Two pairs of feet. Moments later, Robert and Mr. Prang were together stooping down to seize the piano's edge, hoisting the thing several inches into the air, just enough to permit Hanson to breathe.

At once he gasped, coughed, and sputtered, and from his lips there issued forth a spectacular gob of phlegm, yellowish in hue and glistening like varnish. *Too much tobacco,* he thought grimly, his mind reverting to domestic admonitions. *Lavernia was right—as always.*

As Hanson wheezed and spat, his brother surveyed the ruin. "Mr. Prang," Robert said at length, "have you seen any of the ladies of the house?"

The manservant replied: "I have not, Your Honour."

"Brother," Robert said, more pointedly now.

Hanson, still engaged in the exhalation of his humours, failed to respond.

"Hanson!"

At last he looked up—his face half-covered in mucus.

"Your wife and daughters," Robert said. "Where are they?"

Hanson, unable to speak, shook his head in response. He did, moreover, commence to wriggling until he had extricated the bulk of his limbs from beneath the instrument.

The search commenced thereafter with an air of solemn procedure. For it is no easy task, nor brief, to rummage amongst splintered wainscoting and charred *fauteuils*, lifting aside scorched draperies and overturned ottomans in hopes of discovering either survivors or remains. Their search persisted no fewer than three and one-half hours.

It was during this tumultuous excavation that Mr. Prang, emitting the cry of a strangled peacock, stumbled upon what remained of Mr. Frickle, the doorman. His body was slumped against the marble wall of the front vestibule. His head, however, was missing, having been entirely severed from its customary location by what appeared to be a sterling silver platter, projected at velocity sufficient to accomplish instantaneous decapitation. The implement in question (bearing the full Wedgwood tea-service, now irreparably mingled with the blood of the deceased) remained impaled in the masonry some two feet above the stump.

Robert crossed himself. Hanson produced a small notebook from his inner coat pocket and, after consulting a column of liabilities, added "Doorman" to the list.

He then gave a small cough—half fluid, half relief—and added, "God willing, the underwriters are as liberal as the premiums were extortionate."

It was not until the hour at which the sun had begun to retreat behind the blasted remnants of the Western horizon that the party did at last come upon the remains of the Ladies Vivian. The scene presented itself thus: A grotesque tableau formed beneath the ruins of what had once been the drawing-room ceiling. Beneath this heap lay three dainty pairs of feet, protruding.

Upon its discovery, Hanson, in the midst still of calculating damages, dropped both pen and notebook. He neither exclaimed nor sighed; no oath escaped his lips, nor did any visible weeping ensue. Rather, he stood in a state of transfixion. His posture upright, limbs rigid, gaze vacant—but not aimless. From his right eye, a single tear, solitary and austere, traced its course down the plane of his cheek, before vanishing into the stubble of his unshaven jaw.

Robert approached and laid a hand upon his brother's shoulder. He muttered a prayer, or something akin to a prayer. Mr. Prang, for his part, produced from the inner pocket of his waistcoat a linen handkerchief and applied it to the corners of his eyes.

Thus the men remained, fixed in posture and united in a silence far more expressive than any lamentation, until the first cock proclaimed the dawn. At this signal, Robert and Prang began to remove—by hand, plank by plank—the debris that had encased the ladies. Hanson did not move. Indeed, not once, in the entire interval betwixt the first glint of morning and the final covering of the corpses, did he so much as incline his neck or alter his ocular fixity. As to what object had captured his gaze—whether some distant metaphysical horizon or merely the charred remnants of the eastern parlour—none could say with confidence.

Once the bodies had been drawn forth—grievously bruised, their garments rent, their faces only half-preserved—they were enwrapped in bedsheets, which Robert procured from the least-damaged of the linen cupboards, and which Prang affixed with several lengths of curtain-cord. No ceremony was spoken, though each man paused, in his fashion, before lifting a limb or adjusting a fold.

Still Hanson did not stir. Robert had never seen a man so thoroughly broken—not by pain exactly, nor by madness, but by the intolerable arithmetic of loss, which renders the most calculating mind a beadless abacus.

V

As the city of Pandora did, by degrees most painful and deliberate, begin its slow rise from ruin, it was adjudged by the surviving members of the the Commons, and with the solemn approbation of the ecclesiastical authorities, that a Procession of Mourning be enacted, both as a token of reverence for the perished noblesses and as an exemplar of communal unity. The procession was led by His Most Reverend Eminence, the Archbishop of Cantburg, a figure whose scarlet cope and gilded crozier did shimmer against the ashen greys of the ruined cityscape like a cardinal alighted on the burnt remains of some once-flourishing grove. Horns sounded forth with such tragic grandeur as to shake loose the plaster from those few ceilings still uncollapsed. Choirs of orphans sang as the mourners wended their way through avenues choked with rubble, the onlookers weeping, pressing themselves into doorways, and clustering upon stoops, their garments scorched, their heads bowed.

Hanson had not uttered a syllable, he neither knelt nor trembled. It was not until the moment at which the funereal rites were concluded—at the

very instant, indeed, when the last of the three coffins was lowered into the crypt, the very structure which had sheltered Robert—that Hanson at last moved. He approached his brother, placed a hand upon his shoulder—his voice emerging like a creaking casket—"I am leaving, Robert."

One must imagine Robert's astonishment, for he was wholly unprepared for such a declaration, and responded accordingly: "Wherever to, Hanson? Your people need you—now, more than ever. Look at what has become of your city!"

Hanson, however, met his brother's eyes without flinching and replied in a low voice: "To the Catherine Isles. There is a monastery there, which possesses the most sophisticated astronomical apparatus in all the known realms. And—eh, er—well, I have questions. Questions," he added, lowering his voice as if to avoid embarrassment, "to which Reason has no answer."

Robert, to his credit, did not press the point, but instead nodded gravely, for he understood—perhaps not the content of the questions, but the necessity of the asking. "But who," he inquired, "shall take your place? Are you, then, retiring as Governor?"

At this Hanson made a gesture—not quite a shrug, but a motion of the hand which implied both resignation and wry amusement—and pointed in the direction of Mr. Prang, who at that moment was bent over the lawn gathering dampened tissues, all of which had formerly served to blot the tears of the grieving mourners.

"Mr. Prang," Hanson declared, "shall assume the post. As you well know, our Commonwealth maintains a strict Balance of Powers. The Governor holds only the power to veto policy. So long as he agrees with their legislation, which he shall, he may live in luxury, nibbling upon delicacies and presiding over galas. Meanwhile, the actual administration is conducted by civil functionaries of my appointment."

The very next morning, the brothers departed—Hanson to sea, robed in a black traveller's cloak; Robert to Angelinia, where affairs of State, commerce, and no small number of love-letters demanded his signature.

* * * *

There are few spectacles more instructive, and more dispiriting, than a legislative assembly in the aftermath of disaster. Thus it was on the morning of the sixteenth of April—being the seventh day after that calamity already dignified with the name of the *Bloody Easter*—that the surviving members of the House of Commons assembled beneath the sundered dome of the capital building, the walls draped, with an industry more zealous than successful, by order of Governor Prang, whose exertions in restoring appearances had not yet extended to restoring confidence.

By the hour of nine, the hall was already filled. Among those present sat Severin Blodgett, Chairman of the Press, occupying the third bench from the front on the right-hand side. Near him was Lord John Manley, who, as attendance was called, fixed his attention exclusively upon the person of the Governor, and did not turn, though Blodgett addressed him.

"Tragic, is it not?" said Blodgett.

Manley, without shifting his gaze, replied, "My dear Severin, you need not exert yourself on my account; I am not so delicate as to require the courtesies of tragedy."

It might have been supposed that such a reply would discourage further advance; but Blodgett would not be deterred. He asked again.

"I have suffered some," said Manley, relapsing into silence.

Blodgett, adopting the direction of Manley's gaze, observed the figure of the Governor, noting the beads of perspiration forming beneath his wig.

"And what judgment do you form," he asked presently, "of our new governor?"

"None," said Manley, turning at last. "Who is he?"

Blodgett smiled and replied, "He was the Governor's manservant—so I hear."

Manley did not return the smile.

Governor Prang, who had been shuffling his papers anxiously, struck the gavel, ordering silence in the chamber. He began to outline the business of the day, holding his papers as though he believed they might otherwise escape him—as indeed his composure seemed perpetually on the verge of doing.

"We are to consider," he said, "the Good Samaritan Act, by which we shall restore Pandora and its surrounding municipalities to their former condition. This will necessitate certain sacrifices—temporary, I am

assured—including reductions in salary and increases in taxation upon land and shares."

It is not difficult to imagine that such proposals, under any circumstances, would meet with resistance; but here the response was immediate. Murmurs arose, until it seemed the very air was vibrating with discourse.

Manley tugged at the cuffs of his shirt, yet he did not speak. Blodgett, by contrast, lit his pipe.

"Yes, I am aware it is unpopular," Prang continued. "Nevertheless, my advisers—"

"I object!" cried one voice.

"I second!" came another.

The Governor struck the gavel again, though with diminished effect. "Order! I must have order!"

"Here, Your Excellency, is the order you require," said Count Falzac; and with that, relieved himself upon the floor.

Wigs were removed—some were cast in the direction of Prang, others were abandoned—and the members departed. The chamber, so recently full, emptied itself with equal rapidity. Scarcely a third remained; among them Blodgett and Manley. Governor Prang stood gazing stupidly at the remnant, his mouth slightly open; the gavel fell from his hand and struck the floor with a resounding THUD.

There were whispers among those who remained. The question, present to all: *What was to become of their country?*

At last Manley allowed himself to smile. He inclined his head to Blodgett, who, recognizing the signal, rose and followed him. They passed into the foyer, where Manley, clasping his hands behind his back, directed his gaze upward toward a ceiling fresco in which Reason—represented as a woman crowned with fire—raised the flag of Calverinia above the prostrate forms of Doubt, Chaos, and Decadence. It might have been observed, though Manley did not remark upon it directly, that Reason had lost her head, and that dark clouds had gathered in its place. He kicked at the fragments of marble and plaster that lay scattered underfoot and clicked his tongue.

"I confess, Severin," he said at last, "that I am very displeased."

Blodgett, who had been watching him pace, asked, "What is it?"

Manley stopped, turned, and looked at him. "A nation, my dear friend, requires strength—above all in moments such as these. And yet—where is it to be found?" He extended his arm toward the ruin that surrounded them. "Observe what has been left to us."

Blodgett did, indeed, observe.

Manley picked up a fractured bust of Caesar and placed it upon the headless Athena. He stepped back and regarded the arrangement for a moment. Then he walked toward the door.

* * * *

The Good Samaritan Act died as such acts generally do—not in dramatic defeat but in the quieter fatality of indifference. Those who require the particulars may consult the footnote below. Within the week, a pamphlet had appeared in the lower districts of Pandora—cheaply printed; its title, set in bold gothic type, read:

RESURRECTIO PATRIAE!

> *Pro stultis habiti estis!* The seat of power has been stolen! You are told that the Ladies Vivian perished upon Bloody Easter. *Who has whispered this fiction into your ears? Who has profited from your belief?* Shall we accept that the Governor would surrender his dominion to a *servant*? NO! This 'Governor' Prang robs you, and calls it *charity*, as the wolf dons the fleece so that he may feast on the herd! He fancies himself a 'Good Samaritan', when his hands are coated in blood! In every age, there comes a moment when the mask is torn away, when the people behold, their emperor stands naked before them! That moment is now! No more deception, no more submission, *no more*! Let the liar be cast down! *No more we say! Lock him away!*

None of this was true, of course; but it was, however, considerably more interesting than the truth, and—I confess, with some reluctance—more *fun*.

The pamphlet multiplied. It found its way into taverns and mill-houses, was read aloud to those who could not read it themselves, was passed between hands still floury from the morning's work. By the time

Prang's advisors had formulated a response, the response was already irrelevant. On the fourteenth day of his Governorship, a crowd assembled before the House of Commons with the particular energy of men who have been told, and have chosen to believe, that they have been systematically robbed of what was owed them. They came first in dozens, then in hundreds; they filled the gallery, then the floor; and what had begun as interruption became something closer to siege. The day's proceedings did not so much conclude as disintegrate. Prang was removed through a side entrance by his advisors, his papers still in hand. In the aftermath, when the chamber had been cleared and the damage assessed, it was observed—though observed, it must be said, by none save the Author—that Blodgett and Manley had not been present at all.

The pamphlet's origins were never formally established. They did not need to be. Its publication had proven so precisely timed, so perfectly calibrated to the ambitions of those two men, that the question of authorship answered itself to any who cared to ask it—which, in the event, was very few.

VI

It may, I think, be asserted without hazard of contradiction, that the sudden dissolution of a polity, especially one so variously compounded and delicately balanced as that of Calverinia, operates upon the surrounding nations in a manner not unlike the abrupt removal of a central weight in a mechanical apparatus, whereby the lesser wheels, springs, and counterpoises, do begin immediately to tremble, to oscillate, and in some cases to fly altogether out of their proper orbits. Thus it was, in the present instance, that the intelligence of Calverinia's collapse did not merely alarm but galvanized the courts of Abbieannia, Abyssinkle, and Protestentia; so that their respective governors sought to convene a congress within the Royal Chamber of Robert Vivian.

The congress being thus assembled, Major Thomas Slyne—who attended in proxy for Governor Slonobbian of Abbieannia—did, with scarcely any preamble, urge immediate intervention.

Governor Robert—whose constitution, I must beg the Reader to note, had remained quite delicate since that fateful Easter morn—cast his eye, not upon the speaker, nor upon the maps which lay unfurled upon the table, but rather upon a small imperfection in the upholstery of his chair, namely a

loose thread, which he proceeded to disengage with an attention so total, that one might have supposed the fate of nations to depend upon it.

Meanwhile, Governors Phellinea Tamerline of Abyssinkle and Weimar Sewell of Protestentia did incline their heads in agreement with Slyne's proposal

"Your Excellency?" said Slyne at length.

"Yes," replied Robert, who, having at last detached the thread, had begun to wind it about his finger, observing the gradual alteration of its colour as the circulation beneath was impeded.

"So, is it agreed?" interposed Tamerline.

"Yes," said Robert again.

"When may we expect your assistance?" she continued.

"Assistance?"

At this, Major Slyne emitted a groan, while Sewell demanded with some asperity whether Robert had attended at all to the preceding discourse.

"No," said Robert. Yet when pressed—"You do take it seriously, though?"—he replied, with a slight and not altogether reassuring laugh, "I *do* do take it seriously," unwinding the thread with equal care.

It was at this point that Sewell, turning aside to Tamerline, ventured in a lower tone to inquire into the state of Robert's faculties; to which Robert, raising his eyes at last, replied, "You may ask me directly."

Rising then, he walked to the window, whose panes admitted a view of the garden, wherein his seven daughters were engaged in play.

"I think," said he, without turning, "it is best if we leave the nation to its own devices."

Sewell exclaimed with indignation, while Tamerline questioned his very soul.

Robert's attention shifted to the increasing agitation of the wind, which set the flag above the garden into a violent and irregular motion.

"Robert!" cried Sewell.

Yet before the matter could be pursued further, he had already resolved upon departure, striding swiftly toward the exit.

"Where is your brother?" inquired Tamerline.

"Hiding," scoffed Slyne. "It is his fault."

"Enough!" cried Robert suddenly, with a force that startled all present. "Guards!"

The guards entered and seized the protesting men and removed them from the chamber; Slyne managing, before the door was shut, to pronounce a final warning—"It can happen here, Robert! Act now! Act—"the remainder being extinguished by the closing of the door.

Robert, being at last alone, did place his hand within the pocket of his coat and withdrew therefrom a carefully folded letter. This particular message, which Robert had received some months prior, was brief. It read, in its entirety: *"Seabound, again. For the Blengiglomenean Islands.—H."*

Now here, the attentive reader will perceive at once the peculiar density of implication contained within so few words; for the Blengiglomenean Islands are, by most accounts, uncharted; or, more precisely, charted only in negative terms—that is, as regions to be avoided, circumscribed by cautious navigators who contrive always to pass at no less than one hundred nautical miles from their supposed coordinates.

Such avoidance is not without due cause. Reports, though fragmentary and often embellished, do nonetheless concur in certain particulars: that the waters surrounding those islands are of an unusual opacity; and unspeakable horrors have been drawn from their depths.

Why, then, would Hanson elect to venture there? Why, indeed, would any man? The question, I confess, admits of no immediate resolution; *yet*.

He delicately returned the letter to its folded state, and directed his attention once more to the window. Angelina and Catherine were seated upon a low patch of grass, their fingers deftly interlacing the stems of flowers into the form of a crown. Agatha, Charlotte, and Geraldyn, meanwhile, hopped along the garden path on one leg. Jennie lay upon the grass, surrendered entirely to sleep, her breathing regular; while Elsie, the youngest, stood apart, her small face tilted toward the heavens, counting the clouds in the sky.

A single drop of water struck the earth below. Then another. Then two, three.

"It is time," he said, "to call them indoors."

* * * *

The clouds—layered one upon another in vast, shifting terraces of green and gold—did not merely drift but seemed to assemble and dissolve according to

laws at once arbitrary and inevitable. Elsie observed in them familiar shapes—a grasshopper, a dove, a tea-kettle—each emerging with a clarity that demanded recognition before being reabsorbed into the greater whole; but, darting through the swirling mists, she perceived—(or, as she would later say, "*witnessed*")—a figure unlike the others: a long, sinuous creature, whose wings, when in the pale light of the sun, revealed a spectrum of colors. It was, she thought, something like a serpent, though elevated—ennobled, even—by those wings which lent it a character at once angelic and unsettling.

"Miss Elsie!"

The voice belonged to Gallup, the butler, who stood at the threshold, holding an umbrella. Her sisters had already withdrawn indoors, and the sky, relinquishing its burden, allowed the rain to descend upon her.

"Miss Elsie," Gallup exclaimed, "you will permit me to observe that such disregard for timely instruction can scarcely be reconciled with the expectations of a household such as this. One cannot trifle with the elements and remain unaccountable."

He gathered her up and bore her inside, his newly polished shoes suffering visibly in the process.

"And now," he continued, setting her down, "you are exposed to all the consequences which prudence might have averted. It is my earnest hope, Miss Elsie, that you will one day recognize the wisdom of your elders."

Elsie, however, did not respond. Indeed, she scarcely heard him. For while her body had been removed from the garden, her mind remained fixed upon that fleeting apparition, which even now began to dissolve into uncertainty. Had it truly possessed such colors? Were there two wings or more? And—most troubling of all—what had been the expression of that face—yes, there had been a face, she was certain of it, though the certainty itself seemed already to waver. Without acknowledgment, she broke away and fled upstairs, her urgency incomprehensible to Gallup, who called after her with the weary persistence of one accustomed to being disregarded.

In the nursery, she found Catherine—whose energies were presently directed toward the indiscriminate excavation of the toybox.

"Out!" Elsie screamed.

Catherine continued her search with indifference. Elsie seized her by the hair.

"Ouch!" Catherine cried, turning, "Elsie, what—"

"Leave," Elsie repeated, pressing her toward the door.

"Where's my brush?" Catherine demanded. "You know I know you have it!"

It is true that the brush lay concealed beneath Elsie's bed, and that, under ordinary circumstances, she might have defended her claim to it with a logic both elaborate and sincere. But what was a brush when set against the preservation of something so fragile and so necessary as the memory of that extraordinary vision?

Having expelled Catherine, she secured the door and hurried to her bedside table. There lay a volume entitled *Lady Tulip's Treatise on the Right Behaviour of Women*. Without hesitation, Elsie tore the flyleaf and, taking up a crayon, began to draw. The image, which had threatened to dissolve, now reasserted itself with a clarity that seemed almost independent of her will, passing, as it were, through her hand onto the page. Only when the last line had been made did she pause, and in that pause the vision withdrew, leaving behind its imperfect but sufficient trace: a serpent with the wings of a bird, and—most curious of all—the face of a man.

The door was abruptly opened, and Gallup entered, accompanied by Catherine, whose distress had by now assumed a form at once theatrical and, in her own estimation, entirely justified.

"She pushed me, Mr. Gallup," Catherine said. "I didn't do nothing to her."

"You *did* nothing to her, Miss Catherine," Gallup corrected. "And I must entreat you to mind your grammar."

Elsie projected her tongue in defiance.

"Miss Elsie," Gallup said, "you will recollect yourself."

She lowered her head—not in submission, but in order that her expression might remain unobserved—and concealed the drawing within her stocking. As Gallup led her from the room, enumerating the various disappointments which her conduct would inevitably occasion, she allowed her gaze to wander along the corridor, where the portraits of her ancestors—seventeen generations of Vivians, each distinguished by a uniform severity of aspect and an unmistakable commitment to discomfort—regarded her with that peculiar expression which, though intended to inspire reverence, more often produced in her a quiet and enduring skepticism. She observed the elaborate wigs, the constricting garments, the studied rigidity of posture,

and wondered whether it was indeed necessary, in order to belong to such a lineage, to accept so unquestioningly the burdens it imposed. Whether, in short, discomfort was not merely endured by her elders, but cultivated—cherished, even—as a visible sign of their distinction. And if so, whether she, when her time came, might not choose otherwise.

She was conducted into the study where her father sat at his desk, bent over a series of charts. At her entrance, he raised his head; and Elsie, observed—with relief—that his face bore not the rigid severity she had feared, but instead fatigue. This perception, slight as it was, awakened in her a hope so immediate and so persuasive that it seemed, for a moment, to absolve her entirely; for if he was tired, then surely he would not trouble himself with punishment.

Gallup guided her firmly toward the leather armchair placed opposite the desk, and seated her there. The desk spoke of an earlier age: a heavy mahogany construction, marked by ink and time, resting upon carved lion's feet. Elsie found that her eyes scarcely rose above its edge, and was obliged, with a small and instinctive adjustment, to elevate herself so as to meet her father's gaze. Gallup withdrew, closing the door behind him.

Elsie's father set aside his quill, placing it carefully within the inkwell, and brought his hands together. Elsie thought for a moment, briefly, that he might say a prayer.

Leaning back, he regarded her. There was, unmistakably, a gentleness in his expression. Elsie's confidence swelled in turn. She restrained, with some effort, a smile that threatened to betray her; she was certain—yes, entirely certain—that she would escape.

"Elsie, are you misbehaving?" He said in a tone that was light, and almost playful.

Was this an invitation to confession, or a test of composure? She began to nod, then checked herself, and in the effort to correct her own movement produced instead an ambiguous tilt of the head, which satisfied neither purpose.

Her father smiled—a slow, reflective smile—and, passing his hand over his moustache, regarded her with a mixture of amusement and inquiry.

"What is it, my dear?" he said.

At this, Elsie became suddenly aware of the drawing concealed within her stocking. Should she produce it? Would he see, as she had seen?

Before she could resolve this, he rose.

Moving around the desk he approached her and extended his hand.

"I want to show you something," he said.

Elsie placed her hand in his and allowed herself to be led from the room. They entered the corridor, where the walls presented now, instead of the severe visages of her ancestors, herself, her sisters, her mother, and her father. They passed the music room, from which there issued the clear and disciplined voice of Charlotte, engaged in the performance of *Lascia ch'io pianga*. At length they arrived before the door of her father's bedchamber. A room that, as had been impressed upon her by Mr. Gallup, she was, under no circumstances, to intrude upon.

The door was opened.

She entered.

The room, larger than she had anticipated, bore walls papered in a lavender, dulled by time, overlaid with charts, maps, and diagrams. Pins had been driven into these maps, and from them extended threads of varying colors, intersecting and diverging in a manner at once orderly and obscure. The greater number of these converged upon Calverinia itself; yet one solitary line, more conspicuous for its isolation than its length, stretched outward toward a distant chain of islands in the Mo-Whirthian Sea—names which Elsie, tracing them silently with her eyes, attempted to pronounce and failed.

"Elsie," her father said.

He had released her hand and seated himself upon the edge of the bed. Upon his lap rested a small box. He inclined his head, indicating that she should approach. She obeyed. Seating herself beside him, her attention divided between the object in his hands and the expression upon his face, which, though composed, contained an element unfamiliar. He opened the box. Within lay a rosary of white pearls, delicately strung, from which hung a crucifix of gold.

"This," he said, as he lifted it into the lamplight, "belonged to your mother."

Elsie regarded the crucifix. It seemed to her—though she would not have ventured to articulate the perception—that the figure of the Savior bore an expression not entirely consistent with its suffering. The brow was furrowed, the tears evident, and yet there lingered, at the right corner of the mouth, a faint upward curvature.

Her father placed the rosary around her neck.

"It is now yours," he said. "For your protection."

Elsie raised her eyes to his. She perceived then—more clearly than before—that his face had altered. There were lines where she had not remembered them, and strands of gray that seemed to have appeared without transition. "Papa…?" she said.

"Yes, my dear Elsie," he replied. He smiled, and though the smile retained its gentleness, it bore also the unmistakable trace of fatigue.

She thought then—inevitably, irresistibly—of the vision she had witnessed in the sky. Was it an omen? And if so, of what? That she should connect these things—the creature in the clouds, the rosary, her father's altered face—was not, perhaps, unreasonable; yet neither was it entirely reliable, for the mind, especially in youth, delights in seeking patterns where none have been intended.

They remained thus for some time, neither speaking.

The clock struck nine, and from below there came the sound of Mr. Gallup ringing the bell for supper. The voices of her sisters followed, and beneath them, the steady, corrective cadence of Gallup's admonition.

"Go," her father said, and though the word was brief, it was accompanied by a gesture at once dismissive and affectionate, as though he released her not merely from the room but from the moment itself.

Elsie rose.

She withdrew slowly, her steps measured less by intention than by reluctance, and even as she reached the threshold she maintained her gaze upon him. It was only when she had crossed beyond the door that he turned away, directing his attention once more to the maps upon the wall. As she made her way toward the dining hall, the rosary resting lightly against her chest, Elsie thought that perhaps it ought to be returned. Not from ingratitude, but from a sense—dim, though insistent—that her father would require its protection more than she.

VII

I suspect that your attention has strayed from those earlier, more temperate arrangements of Governor Robert's domestic life, toward the darker and more lurid details of the Calverinian collapse; for the modern imagination inclines, almost by instinct, toward the savage, the carnal, the perverse. That expectation shall not go unsatisfied.

The disorder that followed the circulation of Blodgett and Manley's incendiary pamphlet did not so much subside as gather itself, like a slow boil. Under cover of night, the capital building was set alight; and the fire, once kindled, soared upwards, becoming a tower of flame, and casting a broad and terrible light over Pandora and the lesser municipalities that depended upon her authority. Within that blaze perished the accumulated memory of the state: the archives, the censuses, the charters laboriously drafted and ratified, the bills contested and amended, and, most concerningly, the constitution itself. By morning, the city was, in the literal sense, without law; and the populace proceeded to demonstrate how little they truly cared for each other. Crowds formed and dissolved, their purposes as mutable as their tempers, looting what could be carried, overturning what could not, and setting fire to what remained.

There were, it must be admitted, moments of festivity in the proceedings. Men and women, flushed with drink and indignation, hurled flaming bottles of whiskey and absinthe through the windows of churches and banks, and fed the spreading fires with bundles of pound-notes. Cheers rose, sharp and exultant, interrupted, periodically, by screams—(whether of injury or ecstasy, it was sometimes difficult to determine)—and beneath both, a chorus of sobs.

As for the Governor—Prang, that is—he was found deceased in an alley beneath an overturned barrel of fish.

From the twenty-fourth of April to the third of June, the riots persisted. The great fire of the capital diminished, as all fires must, but in its place arose a multitude of lesser ones, consuming what remained of Pandora's wealth and economy.

Amid this general dissolution, there remained pockets small, fortified, and curiously serene. Manley's estate was one such refuge. Though his smithery had been reduced to ruin by the typhoon, the house itself stood

intact, its cellars well supplied with food and munitions. There he and Blodgett withdrew from the consequences of a disturbance to which they had, in no small measure, contributed. They drank wine, they dined upon dried meats and nuts, and they listened, no doubt with a mixture of satisfaction and unease, to the distant crackle of burning timber and the nearer, less distinguishable sounds of a national body discovering what remained when its organs were removed.

* * * *

"Is it over?" murmured Blodgett. He lay upon the floor of the cellar, surrounded by empty wine bottles. When he attempted to raise his head, he was met at once by a violent disorientation. "John?" he added, more distinctly, though not with confidence.

No answer came.

He forced himself upright, resisting the pull of nausea and confusion which attended the effort, until at last he achieved a seated position. The cellar revealed itself to him slowly. He was surrounded by barrels, organized into regimented rows. It would not have escaped a more reflective observer that there remained, even now, sufficient stores to sustain them for a considerable duration—provided, of course, that restraint, so notably absent thus far, might yet be introduced.

But Blodgett found his attention drawn elsewhere.

Manley was not present. It seemed to Blodgett that the stillness surrounding him was not accidental. Fear swelled within his breast. He moved. Not abruptly, but inch by inch, directing himself toward the staircase. Nothing stirred. The barrels remained fixed, the shadows undisturbed. And yet—was it not precisely this stillness that rendered the scene intolerable? Manley must be somewhere. Behind the stacked timber, perhaps, or among the shelves of preserves. It would be absurd—yes, entirely unreasonable—to suppose otherwise. Should he call again? He hesitated.

"J-John—," he began, though he scarcely articulated; for the act of calling might itself constitute a disclosure—of position, of weakness, of dependence—which he was not prepared to risk.

Then, with a sudden recollection, he reached for his pistol. It was not there. In an instant he understood what game he was playing. He rushed

toward the stairs, displacing, in his passage. *Where is Manley?* Blodgett knew the answer, though he would not allow himself to admit it.

His foot struck the first step. He stumbled and pitched forward; his face met the masonry.

It was then that he heard it. A click. From behind. And with it, the unmistakable pressure—cold, measured—at the nape of his neck. Blodgett closed his eyes. "I un—," he began.

The report of the pistol followed at once, cutting him short, and leaving behind a new silence which, unlike the one that had preceded it, required no explanation.

* * * *

Glandelinia lies apart, being divided from Calverinia, Angelinia, and Abbieannia by the twin rivers Pollianna and Wren, and from Protestentia and Abyssinkle by mountains and mutual dread; while the remainder is clasped by the Mo-Whirthian Sea, embracing broad promontories and vast insular tracts. The Pollianna, descending from the heights of the Protestentian Alps, moves at first westward before falling to the Angelinian Sea; the Wren, by contrast, issues from gentler elevations and wanders among several nations, until it divides itself into six channels into the Mo-Whirthian Sea, abandoning; a seventh is lost in marshes.

Within these natural confines there exists a people who have remained largely untouched by foreign admixture, their isolation secured not only by rivers and seas but by a general disinclination, widely shared, to relinquish a land rude in its surface, rigorous in its climate, cheerless to every beholder and cultivator except those native to it. For it is not merely danger that deters the voyager, though the Mo-Whirthian Sea is sufficiently treacherous; it is also for lack of incentive. Few, having known the rich prospects of Angelinia or Abbieannia, would willingly adopt a country that seems to resist cultivation. The Glandelinians themselves, however, require no such persuasion. In their songs—their only archives—they recount the deeds of ancestors said to have sprung from the very soil they inhabit, and celebrate, with a priority that admits no rival, a native Hercules, whose praises they sing before those of all other heroes as they advance to battle.

I concur in opinion with those who deem the race singularly unmixed, and stamped with a distinct character: stern grey eyes, ruddy complexions, and bodies of a size and strength well suited to violence. They endure cold and hunger with a patience that might be mistaken for virtue, were it not so evidently the product of necessity. The land, though it yields grain and sustains herds—mainly of swine—remains in large measure either forested to excess or surrendered to marsh, as though reluctant to concede itself entirely to human use.

Their political arrangements correspond to the irregularity of their terrain. Authority is not centralized but dispersed among a shifting constellation of fiefs and companies, whose leaders are chosen less for their capacity to command than for their eagerness to expose themselves to danger; and it is by example, rather than decree, that obedience is secured. A general who advances first, strikes hardest, and remains longest in the sight of his followers procures obedience from the admiration he inspires. Yet judgment and punishment are reserved to the priests, so that chastisement appears not as an act of military discipline, but as the instigation of.

When they go to war—and they go often—they do so not as strangers but as kin. Families and clans form the ranks; the cries of women and children, stationed near enough to witness though not to intervene, accompany the advance; and the wounded, returning from the press of combat, present their injuries to mothers and wives. Food is brought, healing administered. It is a powerful arrangement. It is also a perilous one. For the same society that elevates the bonds of kinship in war imposes, in peace, a severity upon its youngest members which admits of no such tenderness. Childhood in Glandelinia is not a season of indulgence but of obligation; the child, once able to stand, is set to labour. Whether this condition be termed apprenticeship or servitude depends largely upon the observer's disposition; the effect, in either case, is the same. A population thus disciplined from its earliest years provides an inexhaustible supply of labour, and it is by this means that Glandelinia has achieved a certain prosperity in manufacture.

The surrounding nations, who professed a uniform abhorrence of Glandelinian practices, discovered a corresponding interest in Glandelinian goods. Before the Bloody Easter, Hanson Vivian had concluded a trade agreement by which Glandelinian merchants were to be admitted into Calverinia, though not, it was specified, before the sixth of June.

On the fourth of that month, Manley set out on foot toward the Pollianna River. He found, upon his arrival, along the opposite bank, thousands of Glandelinians herding their swine toward waiting steamboats, sacks of potatoes and bundles of rugs were carried aboard, intermingled with an assorted goods less easily reconciled with peaceful exchange—rifles, sabres, knives, broadswords—borne openly. For the Glandelinians, it seemed, conducted no business unarmed.

They expected to be received by the sovereign authority of the land into which they were about to pass; yet, having known that authority chiefly through correspondence, they possessed no knowledge of his appearance.

As the first of the Glandelinians stepped from their boats and set foot upon the Calverinian shore, Manley advanced to meet them, his pace unhurried, his manner composed, and his purpose, whatever its ultimate consequence, already fixed.

CHAPTER TWO

I

The village of Aronburg's Run was constructed, with bleak ingenuity, around a single immense corn mill. This mill, whose wheels turned day and night, decided the hours, the seasons, the rhythm of labour, and the permissible span of childhood. Houses leaned toward it like supplicants; streets curved unconsciously to accommodate its shadow; and the air itself was permanently tinctured with flour-dust.

Within this environment there lived a young girl called *Annie*.

Her surname, though eagerly sought after by scholars, has never been satisfactorily ascertained. It is therefore customary, and perhaps fitting, to refer to her either as *the Child of Aronburg* or *Little Annie Aronburg*, as though the place itself had adopted her, or perhaps consumed her, and left her name behind like chaff. One is tempted to infer that the absence of a surname was not an accident of record-keeping but an early symptom of erasure.

Annie was, like all children of Aronburg's Run, a slave of the mill.

This statement, though stark, requires elaboration, for slavery in this instance did not announce itself with chains or auctions (those being considered inefficient), but rather with contracts, ledgers, incentives, and the peculiar arithmetic of modern governance. Following the occupation of Calverinia by the Glandelinians, many families were offered a choice: starvation with dignity, or survival by liquidation. Their assets were few. Their children, alas, were plentiful.

John Manley, whose genius for policy lay not in cruelty but in *optimization*, ensured that the process proceeded smoothly. Parents who surrendered their children early were granted tax abatements, deferred levies, and, in certain cases, commendations for "cooperative patriotism."

The mill's domestic arrangements, if such a term may be applied, were in a bad way. Labour was abundant, compassion scarce, and the cook-shop—a low annex whose odours oscillated between boiled starch and burnt grease—was perpetually short of coin. It was here that Annie was lodged, fed, clothed, and unmade.

She wore what remained after others had finished wearing: garments whose original shapes were now theoretical, whose seams had surrendered. She ate what remained after others had finished eating: crusts, scrapings, and liquids of ambiguous origin, served not so much upon a schedule as whenever a guest had abandoned their plate. The mill's animals—a dog with one ear, and a feral cat—were her habitual table-companions; Annie ate with them beneath the table, from a wooden bowl indistinguishable from theirs.

Correspondence concerning her condition was conducted with admirable regularity. Once a month, a letter was dispatched by her mother, who had been relocated to another town whose name survives only in smudged ink. The replies, sent with equal punctuality, were uniform in tone and content: *The child is thriving. The child is content. The child is well cared for.* These statements, repeated often enough, acquired the authority of fact. Initial payments—modest but sufficient—were soon deemed inadequate. Annie, it was explained, was growing; growth, as every economist knows, entails increased consumption. Sums rose from seven pounds to twelve, from twelve to fifteen, accompanied by intimations that failure to comply might result in "unfortunate disclosures." The mother paid. The mill continued.

By her eighth year—eight years! Pray pause upon the number, Dear Reader—Annie had passed from burden to utility. She swept floors whose dimensions exceeded her height, carried loads whose centres of gravity mocked her strength, and rose before dawn to clear the streets with a broom nearly as large as herself. In winter she shivered; in summer she sweated; in both she worked. The village, observing this arrangement from a comfortable distance, congratulated itself on the charity of the mill's household.

Only her eyes resisted reduction. They remained large, lucid, and disastrously expressive, so that one looking into them perceived not merely sadness but an excess of it, as though sorrow had overflowed its proper vessel and taken up residence there. These eyes would later be described, sketched, exaggerated, sanctified, and finally weaponized by pamphleteers and poets alike. At the time, they were merely inconvenient.

II

Christmas of the year 1801 was, by a curious irony of climate, uncommonly brilliant in Aronburg's Run. The season opened mild; there was neither snow nor hoarfrost to still the ground nor to quiet the air, and the great corn mill continued its rotations with grim regularity. This meteorological indulgence, it may be supposed, encouraged festivity of a sort; for even the most industrious misery will, when spared the extremities of cold, permit itself the illusion of cheer.

Accordingly, a troupe of itinerant showmen erected their painted booths along the principal street, while a band of hawkers and pedlars, operating under the same toleration, unfurled their stalls upon the square before the Meeting-House and allowed them to overflow into Miller's Alley, where stood the mill-owners' tavern. These transient entrepreneurs filled the inns and dram-shops, infused the village with noise, colour, and the temporary impression of abundance, and thus communicated to that ordinarily disciplined settlement a gaiety so boisterous that it bordered upon indecorum.

In the interest of exact historiography—and Pray indulge me here, Dear Reader, for the conscientious chronicler must stoop even to the grotesque—it ought to be recorded that among the curiosities displayed upon the square there appeared a travelling menagerie, in which several frightful clowns, clad in tatters of indeterminate origin and smelling strongly of lamp-oil, exhibited to the mill-hands of Aronburg's Run a winged serpent alleged to have been captured along the Blengiglomenean coast, this creature possessing an eye whose iris was ringed with three concentric colours. A troupe of Glandelinian soldiers attended this spectacle with an earnestness usually reserved for sermons and executions.

On Christmas Eve itself, a number of petty traders were gathered at the table in the public room of the tavern, drinking, smoking, and disputing around four or five candles whose combined luminosity did little more than underline the shadows. The room resembled all such rooms: rough tables scored with knives, pewter jugs dulled by use, bottles, pipes, gesticulating hands, and voices raised not so much in anger as in habitual emphasis. Yet the year 1803 announced itself by two fashionable objects recently acquired by the proprietor: a kaleidoscope, passed from hand to hand and admired for its

infinite rearrangements of the same few fragments, and a lamp of ribbed tin whose light flickered with an air of scientific pretension.

The mistress of the house attended the supper, which revolved slowly before a clear fire like a planet obedient to heat, while her husband drank with the customers and discoursed upon public affairs. These conversations, which touched upon troop movements, grain requisitions, and the wisdom of President Manley's policies, were interlaced with local parentheses of a more practical cast. One might hear, for instance, a miller expounding upon the impurities of Calverinian wheat—tares, fennel, vetch, hempseed, pebbles—and defending, with the logic of mechanical necessity, the resulting quality of flour. "We grind what we are given," he insisted, striking the table with a knuckle like a gavel. "The stones do not discriminate." Nearby, a mower negotiated the future cutting of a meadow.

Amidst this commerce of voices and vapours sat Annie, in her accustomed place upon the cross-bar of the kitchen table near the chimney. She was clothed in rags; her bare feet were thrust into wooden clogs several sizes too large; and by the firelight she laboured at knitting woollen stockings destined not for herself but for the mill-owners, her small fingers moving with a mechanical patience that imitated the wheel outside. A very young kitten, itself uncertain of its tenure, played among the chair-legs. From the adjoining room came the laughter of two well-fed children, their voices fresh and bell-like, punctuating the air with unearned delight.

Above the hearth, nailed in plain view yet rarely remarked upon, hung an instrument of correction—a many-tailed whip whose presence required no explanation.

At intervals there arose the cry of a very young child somewhere deeper in the house. This was a boy, born during a previous winter and now a little more than three years of age. She had nursed him; she did not love him. When his cries grew insistent enough to intrude upon the political debate, the master would remark, without turning his head, "Your son is squalling." To which the mother would reply, "He bothers me." And the child would continue to cry in the dark, as though conducting his own small experiment upon the elasticity of neglect.

Hitherto in this Treatise the keepers of the mill have been presented only obliquely; the moment is now arrived when, in obedience to method, we must walk the circumference of this conjugal engine.

The keepers of the house bore the name McPlaster. Mr. McPlaster had recently traversed his fiftieth year; Mrs. McPlaster was a year or so hence. Thus there existed between husband and wife a certain balance of duration, though not of temperament, nor of conscience, nor of command.

Mrs. McPlaster was a woman evidently designed by Nature for physical labor. Tall, fair, blotched, vast, angular, and yet alarmingly nimble, she belonged unmistakably to that class of colossal females who, at provincial fairs, bend iron and lift paving-stones. She performed every labour of the house with equal vigour and violence: she scrubbed, cooked, hauled, struck, scolded; her voice alone sufficed to make window-panes vibrate, furniture anticipate orders, and children retreat by instinct. Annie served her as sole auxiliary—a relation best expressed, perhaps, by the image of a field-mouse yoked to a threshing-engine.

Her countenance, broad and mottled, bore the aspect of a skimmer dragged through boiling fat; she possessed, moreover, a visible beard, and a talent for profanity so accomplished that her oaths issued like axioms. She boasted, not without demonstration, that she could crack a nut with a single blow of her fist. Save for those infrequent moments—grotesque and theatrical—when some half-remembered romance caused an affected lady to peer forth from the ogress, no observer would have been tempted to remark, "That is a woman." When she spoke, one thought of a drill-sergeant; when she drank, of a carter; when she laid hands upon Annie, of the public executioner.

Mr. McPlaster, by contrast was small, pale, bony, angular, and of so sickly an appearance that it served as perfect camouflage for a constitution of remarkable durability. Here lay the first principle of his art. He smiled habitually, as a man keeps a blade sheathed; he was civil to all, even to those he cheated. He drank as a form of sociability, yet no man had ever succeeded in rendering him drunk.

The tavern itself—known locally as McPlaster's Rest—stood not merely near the great mill of Aronburg's Run, but in strict economic and moral subordination to it. The mill devoured labour; the tavern digested the consequences. Its benches were filled nightly with parents whose children had been sold to the McPlasters, men and women who drank not so much for pleasure as for relief—relief from empty cottages, from small hands no longer

needing shoes, from mouths no longer needing bread. Here contracts were toasted, bargains remembered with pride, and doubts drowned with ale.

Annie, moving silently with jugs and plates, heard these conversations as one hears the regular beat of machinery: incessantly, monotonously, and without pause. She heard fathers calculate aloud how many mouths had been removed from their accounts; she heard mothers speak, with a shamefaced laugh, of sleeping through the night for the first time in years. Such remarks were delivered with the easy tone of men discussing weather or stock-prices. It may be supposed that Annie learned political economy before she learned hope.

Mr. McPlaster governed this house not by violence (which is wasteful) but by suggestion, silence, and a constant invisible pressure, analogous to magnetism, whereby a word—or even a sign—sufficed to set the enormous woman in motion. Observers invariably supposed Mrs. McPlaster to be the master of the house. Error. She laboured; he devised. She thundered; he calculated.

Thus were calculation and fury united in fearful symmetry. And between them was Annie, barefoot in winter, overworked in all seasons, Annie scrubbed, hauled, lifted burdens disproportionate to her frame, and listened—always listened—to adults rejoicing that they had been rid of children like her.

III

Four new travellers had arrived.

Annie, seated low and apart, was at that moment sunk in a species of meditation which bore the inward gravity of thought more commonly observed in monks. Experience, alas, is no respecter of age. Her left eye was darkened and swollen—courtesy of Mrs. McPlaster's fist—an injury which had provoked in that lady not remorse but insult, for she was heard more than once to remark, with a sniff, "How ugly the child looks when she's been struck."

Annie's reflections were not abstract. They were logistical. She was thinking—carefully, anxiously—that night had fully closed in; that the travellers' chambers, by custom and by right, required their pitchers and

caraffes to be filled; and that the cistern had been drained to a degree approaching finality. There was, she knew, no more water.

Mrs. McPlaster lifted the lid of the stew-pan, from which issued a vapour dense with onions. She seized a glass and advanced toward the cistern. Annie raised her head and followed each movement with precision. The tap was turned. A thin, reluctant stream emerged, filling the glass no more than halfway.

"Well," said Mrs. McPlaster, inspecting it with a frown, "there's no more water."

A silence followed—brief, but absolute. Annie did not breathe.

"Bah!" resumed the woman, weighing the glass in her hand, "this will do."

The child bent again to her work; yet for a quarter of an hour her heart leapt in her chest with the violence of some trapped animal.

She counted the minutes, wished for morning, and listened.

From time to time one of the drinkers thrust his head toward the door and exclaimed, "Black as a kiln!" or, "A man would need a cat's eyes to walk abroad without a lantern!" And each such remark, innocent as it seemed, tightened something within her.

At length a pedlar entered abruptly and cried, in a voice sharpened by cold and liquor:

"My horse has not been watered."

"Yes, it has," replied Mrs. McPlaster, without turning.

"I tell you it has not," returned the man.

Annie slipped out from beneath the table.

"Oh yes, sir," she said hastily, "the horse has drunk—a whole bucketful. I carried it myself. I spoke to him."

It was not true. Annie lied.

"There's a brat," said the pedlar furiously, "no bigger than my fist, telling lies as big as the mill-house! I tell you the beast's had no water. I know his breathing. He blows when he's dry."

Annie persisted. Her voice, hoarse with terror and scarcely audible, added:

"He drank heartily."

"Enough!" cried the man. "Have the horse watered, and let this nonsense end."

Annie crept back beneath the table.

"In truth," said Mrs. McPlaster, "if the beast hasn't been watered, it must be."

Then, looking about:

"Well! Where's the other beast?"

She stooped and discovered Annie crouched at the far end of the table, nearly under the boots of the drinkers.

"Are you coming?" she shrieked.

Annie emerged.

"Miss No-Name," said Mrs. McPlaster, with deliberate cruelty, "go and water that horse."

"But, madam," Annie murmured, "there is no water."

Mrs. McPlaster flung open the street door, letting in a slab of night, black as pitch.

"Then go and get some."

Annie lowered her head and fetched the empty bucket from the chimney-corner—a vessel so large that she might, without exaggeration, have sat within it like Diogenes in his tub.

Mrs. McPlaster returned to her stew, tasting it with a wooden spoon and muttering:

"There's water enough at the spring. There never was such a malicious creature. I should have strained the onions."

She rummaged in a drawer of mixed contents and added:

"On your way back, Toad-face, you'll fetch a big loaf from the baker. Here's fifteen pounds."

Annie slipped the coin into the small pocket sewn into her apron. She said nothing. She stood for a moment, bucket in hand, the open door before her, as though awaiting a reprieve from some unseen tribunal.

"Move!" screamed Mrs. McPlaster.

Annie stepped out into the night.

The door closed behind her.[3]

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[3] The Reader will, by this point, have formed certain literary associations which the Author neither confirms nor denies, being himself uncertain whether the events here recorded shaped the novel he suspects the Reader is thinking of, or whether the novel has simply shaped his telling of them.

As the McPlaster tavern stood in that quarter of Aronburg's Run which pressed closest to the church and its bell, it followed that Annie, when dispatched for water, must take her course not toward the orderly channels of the millrace, whose waters were already spoken for by wheels, but toward the forest-spring lying beyond the last habitations, in the direction of that neglected margin where nature still dispensed her fluids without ledger or receipt. This spring, though no more than seven or eight minutes' walk in daylight, expanded by night into a distance of far greater magnitude, as all distances do when measured by fear rather than by feet.

She did not so much as glance at the wares of a single other merchant. The road was illuminated by commerce masquerading as celebration; but soon the final stall surrendered its light, and the last paper funnel flickered out, and the child was plunged into darkness. Yet, as a certain inward agitation overcame her, she contrived to make as much motion as possible with the iron handle of her bucket, thereby producing a clank and scrape which, though paltry as sound, afforded her the illusion of company.

The farther she advanced, the denser the darkness became. The streets were empty. Annie traversed the twisting, half-forgotten lanes which unravelled toward the forest. So long as walls flanked her path she advanced with tolerable firmness. At intervals a candle flickered behind a shutter. People were there; this reassured her. But as she proceeded, her pace slackened, not by deliberation, but by a kind of surrender. When she reached the corner of the last house, she stopped.

To go beyond the final stall had been difficult; to go beyond the final house appeared impossible.

She set down her bucket, thrust her hand into her hair, and scratched her head slowly. Before her lay open fields, black and vacant. She stared into that space where there were no people, where there were beasts, where there were—perhaps—other things. She heard the grass stir; she saw shapes detach themselves from trees. Fear instructed her senses with a precision they never possessed in daylight.

She seized her bucket again. Fear, having reached its saturation point, lent her audacity. "Bah," she said aloud, invoking that syllable of false courage common to all ages; "I shall tell her there was no more water." And she turned back.

She had not gone a hundred paces when she stopped again and scratched her head once more. Now it was Mrs. McPlaster who rose before her imagination: that mouth shaped into a permanent snarl, those eyes flashing with an anger that did not require provocation. Annie cast a glance forward and backward. What was to be done? Before her stood the certainty of punishment; behind her, the possibility of annihilation. She recoiled from the McPlasters, turning again toward the forest and began to run.

She left the village; she entered the trees, no longer looking, no longer listening. She paused only when her breath failed her, and even then she did not halt her advance. She went straight on, by desperation rather than by direction.

As she ran, she felt that she might cry; and the forest quivered.

She no longer thought; she scarcely saw. The immensity of night confronted her.

By some residue of instinct—call it memory, or Providence, or habit—she did not lose her way. Thus she reached the spring.

It was a narrow basin hollowed in clay, two feet deep, bordered with moss and tall, crimped grasses, and paved with stones. The babbling of small brook escaped from it with shocking tranquility. Annie did not pause. She groped for the young oak that leaned above the spring, found its branch, clung to it, bent, and plunged the bucket into the water. Her excitement tripled her strength. In this movement, the coin in her apron-pocket slipped free and fell into the spring, unheard, unseen.

She drew the bucket nearly full and set it down. Then she discovered that she was exhausted. She sat upon the grass.

She opened her eyes because she could not keep them shut. The disturbed water in the bucket traced circles like tin serpents. Above her, clouds massed. Jupiter was setting, enormous and wounded-looking, its red light magnified by mist until it resembled a celestial lesion.

The wind rose. Branches reared and nettles reached with clawed arms. Annie shivered. Terror passed into something deeper, nameless. To escape it she began to count aloud—*one, two, three.* When she finished, she began again.

She rose. Her terror returned, disciplined now into a single aim: to flee. But she dared not flee without the water. She seized the bucket with both hands. It was too heavy. She advanced, paused, advanced again. The water

splashed upon her bare legs; the iron handle numbed her fingers. She walked bent like an old woman.

No one but God saw that.

She sobbed without weeping. She imagined Mrs. McPlaster, always present.

Near an old chestnut she made a final halt, then lifted the bucket once more and cried, "O my God! my God!"—and in that instant the weight vanished. A hand, immense, closed upon the handle and lifted it.

She raised her head. A tall black form walked beside her, silent, erect.

The child was not afraid.

He addressed her, not as an apparition, nor as a master, but as a proposition.

"My child," said he, "what you are carrying exceeds, in strict proportion, the capacity of your frame."

Annie raised her head, and replied—without haste, without tremor—

"Yes, sir."

"Give it to me," he continued, extending his hand "I will undertake the conveyance."

She released the handle. The man resumed his pace beside her, the bucket swinging now at a height consonant with its mass.

"It is, in fact," he muttered, half to himself, half to her, "unreasonably heavy."

After a moment, he asked, "How many years have you accumulated, little one?"

"Eight, sir."

"And you have traversed this distance alone?"

"From the forest spring."

"And your destination?"

"A quarter hour more, sir."

Here he paused.

"So," he said at last, "you are without a mother."

"I do not know," Annie answered, after the briefest calculation.

At this, the man stopped altogether. He set the bucket upon the ground with care, bent, and placed both hands upon the child's shoulders. He attempted to see her face; the sky, lending only indirect assistance, traced her features in outline rather than in detail.

"What is your name?" he asked.

"Annie."

The effect of this syllable upon him was immediate and measurable. He removed his hands, took up the bucket again, and resumed his walk.

"And where," he asked, "do you reside?"

"At McPlaster's Rest."

"That is our direction?"

"Yes, sir."

Another pause.

"And who dispatched you, at this hour, upon such an errand?"

"Mrs. McPlaster."

"And her occupation?"

"She is my mistress. She keeps the tavern."

"The tavern," he repeated. "Indeed. Then it appears I shall lodge there this night. You may guide me."

"We are already on the way," said the child.

They proceeded. The man walked with a speed that suggested not urgency but purpose; Annie followed without effort. The fatigue which had governed her limbs now withdrew. From time to time she looked up at him. She had never been instructed in prayer; yet something within her—call it hope, call it joy—rose upward without words.

After some minutes, he resumed his inquiry.

"Are there no other servants at the tavern?"

"No, sir."

"You are alone?"

"Yes, sir."

She then corrected herself, with the scrupulous honesty of one unaccustomed to abstraction.

"There are two little girls."

"Who?"

"Pollie and Joi."

"And these young ladies—what is their occupation?"

"They work," said Annie, with careful emphasis, "like me."

"Continually?"

"Yes, sir."

After a silence—during which a tear formed but did not fall—she added, "Sometimes, when I am finished, and when they permit it, I amuse myself."

"How?"

"In the best way possible. I have a little lead sword."

She indicated its length with her finger.

"And does it serve its purpose?"

"Yes, sir. It cuts salad. And flies."

By now they had entered the village. The booths stood lit; the church loomed; the tavern waited. The stranger asked, "A fair?"

"No, sir. Christmas."

Near the door, Annie touched his arm.

"Mister… if you please… will you allow me the bucket now?"

"For what reason?"

"If Mrs. McPlaster sees you have carried it, she will strike me."

He returned it to her without remark. An instant later, they stood before the tavern.

The door opened. Mrs. McPlaster appeared, bearing a candle whose flame wavered. "Ah! it is you, then, you little wretch!" she cried. "Mercy on us—what an age you have taken! The hussy has been amusing herself!"

"Madame," said Annie, "there is a gentleman who desires lodging."

At the word *gentleman*, the ferocity in her vanished; a smile—amiable, adhesive, and wholly insincere—took its place.

"This is the gentleman?" said she.

"Yes, Madame," replied the stranger, lifting his hand to his hat with a gravity that suggested allegiance to a vanished code of manners whose extinction he stubbornly refused to acknowledge. "Mr. Henry J. Darger, at your service."

This single movement, together with a rapid but penetrating inventory of his coat (threadbarren), his hat (bruised), and his bundle (spartan in its contents), sufficed to restore Mrs. McPlaster's original disposition.

"Enter, my good man," she said dryly.

He entered. A second glance—more analytical than the first—was exchanged between husband and wife. Mr. McPlaster, still drinking with the carters, communicated his conclusion with a twitch of his forefinger.

"I am exceedingly sorry," announced Mrs. McPlaster at once, "but I have no room left."

"Put me where you will," said Henry, "the attic, the stable; I shall pay as though I occupied a chamber."

"Forty pounds."

"Agreed."

A carter murmured that the price was ordinarily twenty.

"It is forty in his case," replied Mrs. McPlaster. "I do not lodge poor folk for less."

"It ruins a house," added her husband mildly, "to harbour such people."

During this exchange, Henry had seated himself, while Annie placed before him a bottle and a glass, and then resumed her habitual station beneath the kitchen table, where she took up her knitting.

Henry scarcely tasted the wine. His attention had already fixed itself upon the child.

Annie was ugly—ugly in that particular manner which results not from nature's parsimony, but from society's neglect. Had happiness been applied to her face, even sparingly, it might have produced beauty; but fear, fear repeated, fear systematised, had settled upon her features like a scar. She was eight years old by the calendar, scarcely six by the body, and immeasurably older by the eyes.

Fear had become her second skeleton. It governed the angles of her limbs, the economy of her breath and space she dared to occupy.

When Mrs. McPlaster demanded the bread, Annie forgot and lied.

The whip was reached for.

At that precise moment Henry intervened, producing, as if by accident, a coin of greater value than the one demanded.

The blow was arrested; the injustice transmuted, as injustice so often is, into profit.

From that moment, Annie's eyes began, very slowly, to learn a new expression: astonishment not wholly divorced from trust.

What followed—the purchase of the stockings, the liberation of the child's labour by the simple application of five pounds, and a doll bestowed with an indifference that was more terrible to Mrs. McPlaster than generosity.

It suffices to observe that, in that low room, a revolution occurred: A child who had been treated, for one evening, treated as a person.

IV

On the following morning, Mr. McPlaster was discovered seated at the principal table of the tavern, a candle guttering beside him, pen in hand, and brow contracted. He was composing a bill. Mrs. McPlaster stood over him. She watched the pen in silence. They spoke not a word. After a quarter of an hour, Mr. McPlaster laid down his pen and regarded the page with dissatisfaction.

"Twenty-three pounds," murmured Mrs. McPlaster.

"*Peuh*," replied her husband.

"He will not pay it," ventured Mrs. McPlaster, thinking—though she did not say so—of the doll bestowed upon Annie the night before, an act of generosity whose memory continued to rankle her.

"He will pay," said Mr. McPlaster, with a laugh.

At that very moment, Mr. Henry Darger entered, bearing his bundle. The bill was placed in his hands. He glanced at it—glanced only, for his mind was elsewhere.

"Is trade good in this town?" he asked mildly.

Mrs. McPlaster, disappointed at the absence of outrage, replied with the customary lamentations: taxes enumerated, margins compressed, burdens aplenty. Annie was introduced into the argument as an expense.

"What if one were to relieve you of her?" Henry asked.

The effect was immediate. Mrs. McPlaster consented.

It was then that Mr. McPlaster re-entered, assumed the centre of the room, dismissed his wife, and said, "I require fifteen hundred pounds."

Henry opened his worn leather pocketbook, removed three bank-notes, and laid them upon the table with the exactitude of a man placing weights upon a scale.

"Fetch the child," he said.

When Mrs. McPlaster summoned her—gently, astonishingly gently—Annie obeyed at once.

She was given clothes, black and complete; she was told to dress; she was not struck.

At daybreak, the inhabitants of the mill-road beheld an old man and a little girl pass toward the capital: the man stooped but resolute, the child grave, bearing a doll and something far more precarious—hope.

Where they were going, Annie did not know. That she was leaving the McPlaster tavern, she understood perfectly.

And for the first time in her short and overburdened life, she walked beside someone without fear, feeling as though she were beside the good God.

V

It was before a structure so deliberately inconspicuous, so obediently mediocre in its external aspect, that Henry at length halted; a house which, by the severity of its plainness and refusal of ornament, had perfected the art of concealment.

Henry, carrying Annie, produced from his coat not one key but several, each differing slightly in length and tooth. The first admitted them into the common stairwell, the second into a corridor whose boards had been worn concave by decades of passage, and the third into the chamber itself.

The room was an attic of modest dimension There was a stove in the corner, its embers still glowing; a long table; three chairs, each of a different manufacture; and, upon the far side, a folding bed screened by a curtain of coarse but clean linen. On the walls hung charts mapping mill districts, transport routes, child-population ratios, and wage gradients, all annotated in a hand alternately neat and fevered. A lantern from the street cast a diluted light through the high window, breaking the air into bands of shadow and illumination.

Henry laid Annie gently upon the bed, without waking her. He lit a candle.

At length daylight asserted itself. The pale December sun sent a narrow ray through the window slats. A heavily laden cart passed in the street below—its mass, velocity, and impact combining to produce a vibration that travelled upward through timber and bone alike. The bed trembled.

"Yes—yes, I am coming!" cried Annie, springing upright, arms extended toward an imagined corner. "My broom—!"

She stopped. Her eyes opened fully. Before her stood Henry, smiling

"Ah," she said, with a nod of immediate acceptance, "then it is true. Good morning, sir."

She espied her doll at the foot of the bed and claimed it instantly, then commenced a rapid interrogation: Where were they? Was the city large? Were the mills far away? Would Mrs. McPlaster ever come here? Each question followed the last with mechanical regularity, like beads sliding on a string.

"How pretty it is," she concluded, surveying the charts, the stove, the mismatched chairs. It was, objectively considered, a poor room; subjectively, it was liberation.

"Must I work?" she asked, after a pause whose length betrayed the habits of years.

"Play," said Henry.

The remainder of the day passed not in idleness, but in that higher form of activity which philosophers have variously described as restoration, reconstitution, or—when speaking plainly—relief. Annie played.

VI

Before we advance a single step further along the narrow causeway of our narrative, it becomes not merely useful but positively necessary—*necessary*, I say—to render an account of the antecedents of Mr. Henry Darger; for men do not fall from the heavens fully formed (though, as you shall shortly observe, some in fact, do).

Our friend, Henry, was born neither in Calverinia, nor in her belligerent sister Glandelinia, nor yet in Angelinia, Abbieannia, or Abyssinkle. He was, rather, a native of the United States of America: a republic youthful in years, boisterous in temperament, prodigious in invention, and possessed of that curious national confidence which inclines a people to believe that whatever *can* be done *ought* to be done, preferably at great speed.

It may be supposed that had Henry remained upon that continent, he might have passed his life in a manner entirely unremarkable: attending Mass with regularity, earning his bread by some obscure but honest labour, and troubling the conscience of the world no more than a grain of sand troubles the sea. Yet history, which delights in the unexpected, had prepared for him a more extraordinary trajectory.

[to be continued]